



Flare'd!

The sun recently erupted into a solar flare once again. Find out details about the event here: <http://dgit.in/fl4ring>

Return of ISEE-3

Is it possible to resurrect a 35-year old spacecraft? Read about the repurposing of the ISEE-3 here: <http://dgit.in/isee3ret>

"Unless..." Godric went to his computer and started typing frantically. Celeste went up behind him and looked at his screen. "What are you –" "Shhh. Just give me a few specs. I think I have it." So Celeste waited, curious but patient. She took a book off his shelf and settled down on his bed, knowing that it'll take him more than a few specs to do whatever was on his mind. But she understood. About a quatre later, the typing stopped. Celeste looked up to see Godric reading the code off his screen, as if double-checking his calculations. She put the book down and walked up to him, reading what he'd come up with. It looked like – "Wait... what?"



"You did what?" The Praetor looked shocked.

Godric smiled. "Yes, sir."

"This, I have to see." He got up from his chair and took the data module Godric had brought with him. He walked up to his gaming console and plugged it in. Then hesitated.

"You're sure this is safe?"

Godric laughed. "It won't bite, engard. Computer. Run program."

The room dissolved around them. They now stood on a hillside, overlooking a blue lake. A man stood in front of them, smiling.

"Godric! Good to see you again!"

"And you, Sam. How are you?"

The farmer snickered "The same old. It's harvest, so busy, busy."

Godric smiled back, "We won't take too long, then. I presume you know Praetor Walrik?"

"Of course!" Sam touched his forehead with his index finger, with the tip of his thumb resting on his nose. "Haoh-ni, Praetor." The Praetor looked flummoxed, but with due credit, didn't forget his manners. He mirrored the farmer's gesture. "Haoh-ni." Godric grinned and took a spec to enjoy the moment. Then moved on to business.

"So tell me, Sam. Do you know about the Havalas?"

"Of course." He turned to the Praetor. "You and Godric are Havalans. Inhabitants of Gamesverse."

"And do you know what you are?"

"Yes. I'm a human. Part of a computer-generated world created by you, Godric."

The Praetor decided to speak. "And how does that make you feel?"

"Feel? Enlightened, to be honest. It's not every day that a species can claim to coming face-to-face with their creators."

The Praetor stared at the program in front of him. "Extraordinary!" Godric stepped in. "They know what they are. Knowledge of us is a part of their programming."

"But why? Why would you do something so drastic?"

Godric grinned. "Because I made a few modifications to the Harte engine." He turned to Sam. "Hey, so I'll meet you tomorrow for our weekly chess match?"

"Oh, not tomorrow, my friend. Wife's birthday tomorrow."

"Oh! Wish Jazia for me, will you?"

"Of course! And Godric – about your little project with the Egyptians..."

"The Pyramids? What about them?"

"Maybe you should ask them to stop. They're already on a third!"

Godric cursed. "A small programming glitch, I suppose. I'll straighten it out. See you, then. Thanks a lot!"

"No problem, my friend. I'll see you around."

"Computer, end program." The hills promptly faded melted away into the walls of the Praetor's office. "You see what he did there? He decided to cancel a plan with me because of a busy schedule. The Harte engine, Praetor, has been programmed with a sense of free will. Thus making any part of the program as realistic as life, itself. In this case, even artificial wives make you sleep on the couch if you forget their birthday!"

The Praetor managed a weak smile. His brain still trying to catch up with what he had just witnessed. "But if they are self-aware..."

"They are also hard-wired to believe that theres no way for them to cross into our world."

Godric sat down. "The opportunities to use my program for new games are limitless."

The Praetor took a few specs to gather his thoughts.

"Okay, Godric. I'm interested. I'm putting you in charge of the next game release."

The Havalan programmer beamed. "Thank you, engard!"

EPILOGUE:

"Computer, pause simulation."

Godric and the Praetor froze in mid-handshake. The whole world stopped, in fact.

Celeste materialized from the wall. "Reduce North wall opacity to zero." The office wall faded away to reveal the audience sitting in the Maxima, watching the simulation.

"As hypothesized, this program works exactly as we meant it to. The characters in the game are as close to alive as they're going to be." Celeste stopped for a second, looked around at her people in the audience, and then back at Godric's frozen smile.

I hope you knew what you were doing.

"I have been trying to solve the Bartholomew equation, though. Taking the program out of the realm of the virtual, and bringing it closer to what we call reality. And I believe I've found the answer. Actually, my program found the answer for me. Computer – run program patch Godric-one-gamma-pie." There was a pregnant pause, followed by a beep, indicating end of program.

"As of now, each and every character in my program knows that we exist."

A soft murmur rippled through the crowd. People shifted in their seats, and some even stood up to take a closer look at the stage. Celeste turned back to the Havalans.

"Computer, continue simulation."

Havala resumed its motion. Godric and the Praetor turned around to face Celeste. Both of them looked at her, and knew who she was. What she was. Godric had a look of confusion interlaced with awe. In all the time they had known each other, this was the first time she had seen him looking so lost. And yet, those eyes had more than just dumbstruck surprise, fear and cold recognition. There was something warm in there. Admiration. Affection. Mixed with the excited incertitude that their unique situation brought.

Celeste cleared her throat. "Hello, Godric." 